



A COUPLES CONNECTION GUIDE & JOURNAL

Still Choosing You

*Keeping your relationship strong through the
kids, the stress, and the hard times — one
small turn toward each other at a time.*



by **Jamie Wigg** — Dad's Code

PRESENT, NOT PERFECT.

START HERE

Choosing each other on the ordinary days

Nobody warns you that the real test of a relationship isn't the big dramatic moments. It's a wet Tuesday, both of you running on four hours' sleep, a kid with a temperature, a sink full of dishes, and a phone that won't stop buzzing.

My wife Vanessa and I have a line we come back to: *we stay together to conquer anything*. Not because it's always easy — it hasn't been. We've been through illness, through burnout, through seasons where we were more like two tired colleagues running a small chaotic business than two people in love. And still, somehow, we keep choosing each other. Again, and again, and again.

That's what this little guide is about. Not grand gestures. Not a weekend away you can't afford or find a babysitter for. Just the small, repeatable turns toward each other that keep a marriage warm when life is doing its best to cool it down.

Inside you'll find five short ideas, each with one tiny action you can actually do this week. Then twenty questions to ask each other — slow ones, real ones — with room to write. And a weekly "us" check-in you can come back to for years.

Do it together if you can. Do it scrappy if you can't. There's no gold star for finishing — only the quiet win of two people deciding, one more time, that they're worth the effort.

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FIVE SMALL IDEAS

The turns that keep you close

Five things, each small enough to do tired. Read one, do the action, see what shifts. You don't need all five at once — start with the one that pricks at you.

IDEA ONE

Connection over chaos

When the house is loud and the to-do list is screaming, connection feels like a luxury you'll get to "later." But later rarely comes. The couples who stay close aren't the ones with more time — they're the ones who make tiny turns toward each other inside the chaos, not after it.

A relationship is built in the micro-moments: a hand on the back as you pass in the kitchen, looking up when they walk in the door, a ten-second hug that lasts long enough to actually mean something. These don't cost time you don't have. They cost attention you keep giving away to your phone.

TINY ACTION

Once today, when your partner walks into the room, stop what you're doing for five seconds. Make eye contact. Say something — even just "hey, you." That's the whole turn.

IDEA TWO

Repair beats winning

You will get it wrong. You'll snap when you're tired, misread each other, dig in over something that won't matter by Friday. The strong couples aren't the ones who never fight — they're the ones who repair fast. Repair beats winning every single time.

Apologising first isn't losing. It's choosing the relationship over your ego. "I'm sorry, I was sharp with you, you didn't deserve that" defuses more than any perfectly-argued point ever will. The goal was never to be right. The goal was to stay close.

TINY ACTION

Next time there's friction, be the one to reach back first — within the hour, not the day. A short, clean apology, no "but." Watch how quickly the wall comes down.

IDEA THREE

Notice out loud

Appreciation is oxygen. We notice plenty about each other — the meal cooked, the early start, the patience with a toddler melting down — but we keep it inside our heads where it does no good. The relationship breathes when you say it out loud.

It's easy to drift into a partnership that only talks logistics: bins, pickups, who's got the dentist. Spoken appreciation breaks that spell. It tells your partner they're seen — not just as a co-parent or a co-worker in the family business, but as someone you still admire.

TINY ACTION

Before bed tonight, name one specific thing they did today that you appreciated. Specific, not generic. "Thanks for handling bath time when I was wiped" beats "thanks for everything."

IDEA FOUR

Share the invisible load

So much of running a family is invisible work — the remembering, the planning, the worrying, the mental tabs that never close. When one person carries most of it, resentment grows quietly, even when nobody's being lazy. You can't split a load you won't name.

This isn't about a perfectly equal scorecard. It's about making the invisible visible — saying out loud what's actually being held — and then deciding together who carries what. Often your partner doesn't know how much you're tracking. Naming it is the first relief.

TINY ACTION

Each of you name one invisible task you've been carrying that the other might not see. Pick one to genuinely hand over this week — fully, without taking it back.

IDEA FIVE

The intimacy of small acts

Intimacy isn't only the big stuff. It lives in a cup of tea made the way they like it, a kiss before work that isn't on the way to anything else, a hand found in the dark. Small acts say *I was thinking of you* louder than any grand gesture.

When you're deep in the parenting years, the small acts are sometimes all you've got — and that's enough. They're the threads that keep two people woven together through the seasons where energy is short and time is shorter. Tend them and the closeness survives almost anything.

TINY ACTION

Do one small, unprompted thing for them tomorrow morning. Tea in bed. A note in their bag. A real kiss before the door. No occasion required — that's the point.

"We stay together to conquer
anything."

— the line Vanessa and I keep coming back
to

20 questions to ask each other

Pick a couple at a time — over dinner, in the car, lying in the dark. Take turns. There are no wrong answers, only honest ones. Write a few down if you want to remember where you were when you asked.

01

When did you last feel really chosen by me?

02

What's one thing I do that makes you feel loved without me saying a word?

03

What part of this season of life feels heaviest for you right now?

04

When did we last laugh until it hurt — and how do we get more of that?

05

What did you need from me last week that you didn't ask for?

06

What's one invisible thing you carry that you wish I noticed more?

07

Where do you feel furthest from me lately, and where do you feel closest?

08

What's a small thing I used to do that you miss?

09

When you picture us in five years, what do you hope is still true?

10

What's a hard thing we got through together that you're quietly proud of?

11

How do you most like to be comforted when you're stressed or low?

12

What's one way I could make your mornings easier?

13

What's something you've been wanting to say but haven't found the moment for?

14

When did you last feel like a team with me, and what made it click?

15

What's one fear about us you've never quite said out loud?

16

If we had two free hours, no kids, no phones — how would you want to spend them with me?

17

What's something I do well as a parent that I should hear more often?

18

How are we doing at repairing after we argue — and what could we do better?

19

What does feeling wanted look like for you these days?

20

If you had to remind me of one promise we made each other, which would it be?

The weekly "us" check-in

Ten minutes, once a week. Same three questions every time. Sit together, no screens, and take turns answering each one. Print this page, or copy the three lines into a notebook and keep it going.

Week of _____

1. What went well between us this week?

A moment you felt close, a turn toward each other, something the other did that landed.

2. Where did we drift, or what felt hard?

No blame — just honest. Name it so it doesn't go quiet and turn into resentment.

3. What's one thing we'll choose to do for "us" next week?

Small and specific. One date, one task to share, one habit to try. Agree it together.

ONE MORE TIME

Keep choosing each other

You won't get it perfect. Some weeks you'll skip the check-in, snap when you shouldn't, fall asleep mid-sentence. That's fine. Love built in the parenting years isn't tidy — it's stubborn. It's the daily decision to turn back toward the person beside you, even when you're tired, even when it's hard.

That's the whole thing. Not perfect. Present. Still choosing you.

If this helped, come find the rest of the conversation. The **Dad's Code** podcast is where I talk honestly about marriage, fatherhood, burnout and showing up — for the people who matter most.

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DAD'S CODE

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